ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Present and future deduction

Use must, might, may, could and cannot to grade conclusions about current situations and future possibilities. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use present and future deduction to match modal strength to the available evidence instead of stating guesses as facts while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use must, might, may, could and cannot to grade conclusions about current situations and future possibilities.

MODEL

The server must be processing a large request.

must / may / might / could / cannot + base or be + -ing

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main present and future deduction patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses match modal strength to the available evidence instead of stating guesses as facts.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in problem-solving, prediction, investigation and careful conversation.

Build meaning before form

Use must, might, may, could and cannot to grade conclusions about current situations and future possibilities.

What present and future deduction communicates

Use must, might, may, could and cannot to grade conclusions about current situations and future possibilities.

The central purpose is to match modal strength to the available evidence instead of stating guesses as facts. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The server must be processing a large request.	a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence
The update might solve the problem.	a possible present or future explanation
That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.	a conclusion ruled out by evidence

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: must / may / might / could / cannot + base or be + -ing. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The server must be processing a large request.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Strong deduction	must + base / be + -ing	The server must be processing a large request.
Open possibility	may/might/could + base	The update might solve the problem.
Impossibility	cannot + base / be + -ing	That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence	Strong deduction
a possible present or future explanation	Open possibility
a conclusion ruled out by evidence	Impossibility

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in problem-solving, prediction, investigation and careful conversation. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
must / may / might / could / cannot	base or be	-ing

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: match modal strength to the available evidence instead of stating guesses as facts.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits problem-solving, prediction, investigation and careful conversation.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Strong deduction	must + base / be + -ing	The server must be processing a large request.
Open possibility	may/might/could + base	The update might solve the problem.
Impossibility	cannot + base / be + -ing	That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The server must be processing a large request.	a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence
The update might solve the problem.	a possible present or future explanation
That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.	a conclusion ruled out by evidence

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use must not as the ordinary negative deduction; use cannot.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not treat might as a weak obligation.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use must not when you mean a logical impossibility.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence?

OPTIONS The server must be processing a large request. · The update might solve the problem. · That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a possible present or future explanation?

OPTIONS The update might solve the problem. · That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing. · The server must be processing a large request.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a conclusion ruled out by evidence?

OPTIONS That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing. · The server must be processing a large request. · The update might solve the problem.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The server must be processing a large request.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence · a possible present or future explanation · a conclusion ruled out by evidence

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The update might solve the problem.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a possible present or future explanation · a conclusion ruled out by evidence · a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a conclusion ruled out by evidence · a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence · a possible present or future explanation

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The server must be processing a large request." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Strong deduction / Open possibility / Impossibility · Gap 2: a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence / a possible present or future explanation / a conclusion ruled out by evidence

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The update might solve the problem." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Open possibility / Impossibility / Strong deduction · Gap 2: a possible present or future explanation / a conclusion ruled out by evidence / a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Impossibility / Strong deduction / Open possibility · Gap 2: a conclusion ruled out by evidence / a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence / a possible present or future explanation

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence: _____. Choose the model that expresses a possible present or future explanation: _____. Choose the model that expresses a conclusion ruled out by evidence: _____. Choose the model built with must + base / be + -ing: _____. Choose the model built with may/might/could + base: _____. Choose the model built with cannot + base / be + -ing: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing. · The server must be processing a large request. · The update might solve the problem.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The server _____ a large request. The update _____ the problem. That _____ the final version; two sections are missing. State the full structural pattern for Strong deduction: _____. State the full structural pattern for Open possibility: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The delay strongly suggests heavy processing.” using the Strong deduction pattern to express a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The update is one plausible solution.” using the Open possibility pattern to express a possible present or future explanation.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The missing sections make the final-version claim impossible.” using the Impossibility pattern to express a conclusion ruled out by evidence.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The delay strongly suggests heavy processing.” using the Strong deduction pattern to express a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Strong deduction to express a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Open possibility to express a possible present or future explanation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Impossibility to express a conclusion ruled out by evidence, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The server must be processing a large request.

Strong deduction is the best match because a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence.

A2

The update might solve the problem.

Open possibility is the best match because a possible present or future explanation.

A3

That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

Impossibility is the best match because a conclusion ruled out by evidence.

A4

a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence

The Strong deduction pattern communicates a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence.

A5

a possible present or future explanation

The Open possibility pattern communicates a possible present or future explanation.

A6

a conclusion ruled out by evidence

The Impossibility pattern communicates a conclusion ruled out by evidence.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Strong deduction / a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence

The structure belongs to the Strong deduction pattern. Its communicative purpose is a conclusion strongly supported by present evidence.

B2

Open possibility / a possible present or future explanation

The structure belongs to the Open possibility pattern. Its communicative purpose is a possible present or future explanation.

B3

Impossibility / a conclusion ruled out by evidence

The structure belongs to the Impossibility pattern. Its communicative purpose is a conclusion ruled out by evidence.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The server must be processing a large request.

Strong deduction: must + base / be + -ing.

C2

The update might solve the problem.

Open possibility: may/might/could + base.

C3

That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

Impossibility: cannot + base / be + -ing.

C4

The server must be processing a large request.

Strong deduction: must + base / be + -ing.

C5

The update might solve the problem.

Open possibility: may/might/could + base.

C6

That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

Impossibility: cannot + base / be + -ing.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

must be processing

Strong deduction requires “must be processing” in this model. must + base / be + -ing.

D2

might solve

Open possibility requires “might solve” in this model. may/might/could + base.

D3

cannot be

Impossibility requires “cannot be” in this model. cannot + base / be + -ing.

D4

must + base / be + -ing

Strong deduction is built as must + base / be + -ing.

D5

may/might/could + base

Open possibility is built as may/might/could + base.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The server must be processing a large request.

must + base / be + -ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended strong deduction effect.

E2

The update might solve the problem.

may/might/could + base. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended open possibility effect.

E3

That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing.

cannot + base / be + -ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended impossibility effect.

E4

The server must be processing a large request.

must + base / be + -ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended strong deduction effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The server must be processing a large request. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses must + base / be + -ing accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The update might solve the problem. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses may/might/could + base accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

That cannot be the final version; two sections are missing. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses cannot + base / be + -ing accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____